
POLISH EARLY MUSIC 3

WACŁAW Z SZAMOTUŁ

c. 1524 – c. 1560

Modlitwa gdy dziatki spać idą

Już się zmierzka



for four voices
words by Andrzej Trzeciecki

CRITICAL EDITION

from the print of Łazarz Andrysowic, Kraków, c. 1550–1556

edited by Mikołaj Derduń

First edition · 2026

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POLISH EARLY MUSIC 3. Wacław z Szamotuł, *Modlitwa gdy dziatki spać idą*. First edition, 2026. Edited by Mikołaj Derduń.

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Source files, corrections and later editions: <https://github.com/mderdun/pol-ren/editions/juz-sie-zmierzka>.

Set in Junicode; music engraved with LilyPond and Gregorio.

INTRODUCTION

MODLITWA GDY DZIATKI SPAĆ IDĄ ('A prayer when the children go to sleep') is an evening hymn in four six-line stanzas by Andrzej Trzeciecki the Younger, set for four voices by Wacław z Szamotuł. Łazarz Andrysowicz printed it in Kraków as a booklet of four leaves. The print is undated. It belongs with Andrysowicz's other prints of Wacław's Polish songs, which are placed between 1550 and 1556.

The title page names no composer. The letters W and S stand after the final notes of the Tenor, Altus and Bassus, and that monogram is the evidence for Wacław's authorship. Michał Wiszniewski described the print in 1844 as '4 kart. Z nutami na 4 tony W. S.' ('4 leaves. With notes for 4 voices. W. S.')

The setting is a cantional song. The Tenor carries the hymn tune in breves and semibreves, one note to each syllable. The other voices move around it more freely, with melismas on stressed syllables and a clausula at the end of most lines. The tune also appears on its own, unattributed, in Jan Seklucjan's *Pieśni chrześcijańskie dawniejsze i nowe* (Königsberg, 1559). Whether Wacław wrote it or arranged an older tune is disputed: Mazurkiewicz takes it for his, Hławiczka for an older song.

No copy of the print is known today. In 1880 Kazimiera Przyborowska published a facsimile of it in Warsaw, 'z pierwodruku' ('from the first printing'), and every later edition goes back to that facsimile. The usual modern editions transpose the piece up a minor third, halve the note values, add a three-flat signature and modernise the text. This edition gives the music at the pitch and in the note values of the print, draws the bar lines between the staves only, and keeps the old forms of the text.

THE SONG AND ITS USE

The title says what the song is for. Luther's Small Catechism (1529) ends with prayers that 'ein Hausvater sein Gesinde soll lehren' ('a head of household should teach his household'), among them an evening blessing for bedtime: 'denn ich befehle mich, meinen Leib und Seele und alles in deine Hände. Dein heiliger Engel sei mit mir, daß der böse Feind keine Macht an mir finde.' ('for I commend myself, my body and soul and all things into your hands. Let your holy angel be with me, that the wicked enemy may find no power over me.') Polish Lutherans took this over directly. The second edition of Jan Seklucjan's *Catechismus* (Königsberg, 1549) closes with a *Nauka dziecienna*, a teaching for children, which tells them how to begin and end the day:

'Idąc spać mają dać dobrą noc swoim starszym, a niż się układają, mają się naprzód przeżegnać ... [i] te modlitwę mogą przydać: Wszchemogący Ojczy niebieski, dziękuję Tobie ... iżeś nas tego dnia raczył we zdrowiu zachować i wszelkiej szkody uchronić ... a przeto my ciała swoje i dusze i inne wszystkie rzeczy w ręce Twoje polecamy, aby Twój święty anioł był przy nas, aby dyabeł żadnego prawa do nas nie miał.'

('When going to sleep they are to bid their elders good night, and before they lie down they are first to cross themselves ... [and] they may add this prayer: Almighty heavenly Father, we thank you ... that you have deigned to keep us in health this day and to preserve us from all harm ... and therefore we commend our bodies and souls and all other things into your hands, that your holy angel may be with us, that the devil may have no claim on us.')

Trzeciecki's third and fourth stanzas put this prayer into verse almost clause by clause. The holy angel is sent against the enemies of the soul; God is asked to keep the household 'przez wszej szkody' ('without any harm') and from every sudden 'przygoda' ('mishap'); everything the household has is put into his care. The song is the catechism's evening prayer, made singable for the family.

Behind both stands Compline, the old night office, which the household prayer replaced. Its texts are close to Trzeciecki's first stanza. The short lesson warns that 'adversarius vester diabolus tamquam leo rugiens circuit' ('your adversary the devil, as a roaring lion, goes about'); the hymn *Te lucis* asks 'hostemque nostrum comprime' ('and hold back our enemy'); Psalm 90 promises safety 'a negotio perambulante in tenebris' ('from the thing that walks about in

the dark’); the collect asks God to drive off ‘omnes insidias inimici’ (‘all the snares of the enemy’) and to let his holy angels keep the house in peace. The parallel is my own reading; I know of no study that makes it.

The hymnals show the song in this domestic use. Zaremba’s Calvinist *Pieśni chwał boskich* (‘Songs of God’s praises’; Brest, 1558), printed for Mikołaj Radziwiłł, Wacław’s patron, has the text, in a book that also contains Jakub Sylwiusz’s *Pasterstwo domowe*, an order for prayer and singing in the household. Seklucjan’s hymnal of 1559 prints the tune among eight songs headed ‘Idąc spać’ (‘Going to sleep’). Agnieszka Leszczyńska has suggested that Wacław wrote partly with young singers in mind, since the Tenor’s plain tune could go to the least practised voice.

Trzeciecki (c. 1525 – after 1584) was a Kraków humanist and a leader of the Reformation in Little Poland, a friend of Kochanowski and one of the translators of the Brest Bible (1563). He knew Wacław well. He wrote verses in praise of him for the *Lamentationes* (1553) and, after the composer’s death, an elegy, *De obitu Venceslai Samotulini* (‘On the death of Wacław of Szamotuły’).

SOURCES

- Ⓐ *Modlitwa gdy dżyatki śpąć idą*. W Krakowye v Łazarzā Andrysowicā. Undated [c. 1550–1556]. Four leaves, signed A. Title and woodcut of two children kneeling before their parents (A1r); Cantus (A1v) facing Tenor (A2r); Bassus (A2v) facing Altus (A3r); stanzas 1–3 (A3v); stanza 4 and ‘Dokończenye’ (A4r). Clefs C1, C3, C4, F4; cut-C in every voice; no signature, no accidentals. No copy known.
- Ⓕ Facsimile of Ⓐ: ‘z Pierwodruku wznowiła Kazimiera Przyborowska. Warszawa. 1880 r.’ Warsaw, Biblioteka Narodowa, Podr.SD Mag.F I.6, on Polona. A redrawn copy, not a photograph. *Base text*.
- Ⓔ Jan Seklucjan, *Pieśni chrześcijańskie dawniejsze i nowe* (Königsberg, 1559), p. 115: the tune alone.

The print itself is lost, and Ⓕ is a hand-drawn copy of it. Ⓔ has not yet been collated. Editions collated:

- Ⓜ *Już się zmierzcha. Na chór mieszany a cappella*, Polska Literatura Chóralna 208 (Kraków: PWM, 1955). Up a minor third; tempo, dynamics and breath marks added.
 - Ⓚ *Modlitwa, gdy dżiatki śpąć idą*, Towarzystwo Muzyczne im. Edwina Kowalika (2015). Stanzas 1–2 underlaid.
 - Ⓜ Maia McCormick, *Modlitwa, gdy dżiatki śpąć idą* (2024).
- Ⓜ, Ⓚ and Ⓜ agree in every note with Ⓕ, apart from the places listed in the critical notes.

EDITORIAL METHOD

Pitch, values and barring. As in Ⓐ: final D, no signature, no reduction of note values, and the print’s cut-C. A bar is one breve, the tactus of cut-C. Light bar lines run between the staves only, so that none cuts through a note; a note that runs across one keeps its single value, and no ties are added. They serve ensemble and rehearsal, and the parts can be read past them. The incipit before each staff gives the clef, sign and first note of Ⓐ, and the range of each voice follows it. The final notes are longae, as in Ⓐ, and are held until all voices have finished; no fermata is added.

Clefs and voices. The voice names are those of Ⓐ. Altus and Tenor use the octave-transposing treble clef. Written ranges: Cantus c’–d’’, Altus d–a’, Tenor d–e’, Bassus G–a.

Accidentals. Ⓐ prints none, so every accidental here is editorial. They stand above the note and apply to that note only. They are limited to the five cadences where a major sixth opens to an octave (bars 2, 4, 9, 19 and 29), with one optional flat (bar 29, Altus). An accidental in brackets above a note is optional: the note as printed is the edition’s reading, and the bracketed sign an alteration singers may make.

Underlay. ① prints each voice's text as a block under the staff, so the underlay is editorial. Three things in ① guide it. The Tenor's text fits its notes exactly, one syllable to a note. Where ① spaces the words of the Cantus and Bassus apart, it leaves room for a melisma. The line breaks of the other voices give only a rough guide. Elsewhere the underlay follows the rules of this series: no new syllable on a semiminim, except straight after a dotted minim, or on a fusa; a repeated note takes a new syllable where the text allows; the last syllable of a line falls on its cadence note. Where these leave a choice, the words decide. The syllable that carries a line takes its melisma or its high point (*PO-moc*, *CZAR-tów*, *chy-TRO-ści*); a light word such as *o* or *nas* takes one or two notes. The voices do not always change syllable together. At the two main cadences the Cantus comes a minim after the Tenor and Bassus: *nas o-bro-* in bars 19–20, *chy-tro-* in bars 28–29.

Text. ① prints four stanzas and 'Dokończenie' ('The end'), with no Amen. All four are sung to the same music. Old Polish verse counts syllables, eight to the line with a break after the fourth, but not stresses, which fall in different places from stanza to stanza. Stanzas 1 and 2 are underlaid, since most performances sing one or two, and each has its own underlay where the other's would put a melisma on a light syllable: Cantus lines 1, 2, 4 and 6, Altus line 3, Bassus lines 1 and 3. So the Cantus sings *PA-nie* and *pie-KIEL-ne* in stanza 2, *WIECZ-ny PO-kój* where stanza 1 has *CZAR-tów nas*. At the last cadence stanza 1 spreads *swej* over three minims, so that *chy-tro-* trails the lower voices; stanza 2 gives the run to *wo-*, so that *-ta-* falls on the leading note. Stanzas 3 and 4 follow the score and take the notes of stanza 1 syllable for syllable. The transcription uses modern spelling and punctuation but keeps the old sounds and forms: *zmierzka*, *naszem*, *strażem*, *nawiecej*, *wszytki*, *swoję*, *Jesu*, *raczysz*, *wszej*, *jenż*. The diplomatic text keeps the spelling and line division of ①, with *f*, and *ē* unexpanded.



TEXT AND TRANSLATION

A, FOLS. A3V–A4R

TRANSCRIPTION

TRANSLATION

- 1 Iuż fye zmyerzka nádchodźi noc/
 Poprośmy Boga o pomoc/
 Aby on náŕfym ţtrażem był/
 Od złych czártow nas obronił/
 Ktorzy nawyćcey wćyemności/
 Vżywają fwey chytróści.
- 2 Yefu Kryſte Pánye miły/
 Tyś wfłytki pyekyelne ţiły/
 Przez mękę fwoję poráził/
 A nam wyczny pokoy ţpráwił/
 Ráczysz miłóſyerny Pánye/
 Wyſłyſć náſſe wołánye.
- 3 Zeſli Anyoła fwyćtego/
 Aby mocą boſtwa twego/
 Przed duſſnemi przeciwniki/
 Bronił nas twe ţłuźebniki/
 Y záchował przez wfłey ţzkody/
 Od káźdey nagłej przygody.
- 4 Tobyeć wfłycko poruczamy/
 Coż kołwey w fwey mocy mamy/
 Coś nam vźyczyl złáſki fwey/
 Nych to bęđzye wopyece twej/
 Yenz z Oycem y zduchē fwyćtym
 Yeſteś Krolem wykuiſtym.
- Dokończenye.

Już się zmierzka, nadchodzi noc,
 poprośmy Boga o pomoc,
 aby on naszym strażem był,
 od złych czartów nas obronił,
 którzy nawięcej w ciemności
 używają swej chytrości.

Jesu Kryście, Panie miły,
 tyś wszystkie piekielne siły
 przez mękę swoją poraził,
 a nam wieczny pokój sprawił.
 Raczysz, miłosierny Panie,
 wysłuszyć nasze wołanie.

Ześli anioła świętego,
 aby mocą bóstwa twego
 przed dusznymi przeciwniki
 bronił nas, twe służebniki,
 i zachował przez wszelkie szkody
 od każdej nagłej przygody.

Tobieć wszystko poruczamy,
 cożkolwiek w swej mocy mamy;
 coś nam użyczył z łaski swej,
 niech to będzie w opiece twej,
 jenz z Ojcem i z Duchem Świętym
 jesteś Królem wiekuistym.

*Dusk is falling, night is coming;
 let us ask God for help,
 that he may be our guard
 and defend us from the evil devils,
 who most of all in the dark
 put their cunning to use.*

*Jesus Christ, dear Lord,
 by your passion you struck down
 all the powers of hell
 and won us eternal peace.*

*Deign, merciful Lord,
 to hear our cry.*

*Send a holy angel,
 that by the might of your godhead
 he may defend us, your servants,
 from the enemies of the soul,
 and keep us without any harm
 from every sudden mishap.*

*To you we commend
 whatever we hold in our power;
 what you have lent us of your grace,
 let it be in your care,
 who with the Father and the Holy Spirit
 are King everlasting.*

Modlitwa gdy dzieci spać idą

Już się zmierzka

Andrzej Trzeciecki

WACŁAW Z SZAMOTUŁ

CANTUS

ALTUS

TENOR

BASSUS

1. Już się zmierz - ka, nad - cho - dzi noc, po - proś -
 2. Je - su Kry - ste, Pa - nie mi ły, tyś wszyt -

1. Już się zmierz - ka, nad - cho - dzi noc, po -
 2. Je - su Kry - ste, Pa - nie mi ły, tyś

1. Już się zmierz - ka, nad - cho - dzi noc,
 2. Je - su Kry - ste, Pa - nie mi ły,

1. Już się zmierz - ka, nad - cho - dzi noc, po - proś -
 2. Je - su Kry - ste, Pa - nie mi ły, tyś wszyt -

C.

A.

T.

B.

- my Bo - ga o po - moc,
 - ki pie - kiel - ne si - ły

proś - my Bo - ga o po - moc, a -
 wszyt - ki pie - kiel - ne si - ły przez

po - proś - my Bo - ga o po - moc,
 tyś wszyt - ki pie - kiel - ne si - ły

- my Bo - ga o po - moc,
 - ki pie - kiel - ne si - ły

II

C. a - by on na - szem stra - żem był, od
przez mę - kę swo - - ję po - ra - ził, a

A. by on na - szem stra - żem był, od
mę - - kę swo - ję po - ra - ził, a

T. a - by on na - szem stra - żem był,
przez mę - kę swo - ję po - ra - ził,

B. a - by on na - szem stra - - - żem był,
przez mę - kę swo - ję po - - - ra -

16

C. złych czar - tów nas o - bro - nił,
nam wiecz - ny po - kój spra - wił.

A. złych czar - tów nas o - bro - nił,
nam wiecz - ny po - kój spra - wił.

T. od złych czar - tów nas o - bro - nił,
a nam wiecz - ny po - kój spra - wił.

B. - od złych czar - tów nas o - bro - nił,
ził, a nam wiecz - ny po - kój spra - wił.

21

C.

A.

T.

B.

26

C.

A.

T.

B.

3 Ześli anioła świętego,
aby mocą bóstwa twego
przed dusznymi przeciwniki
bronił nas, twe służebniki,
i zachował przez wszej szkody
od każdej nagłej przygody.

4 Tobieć wszystko porucamy,
cożkolwiek w swej mocy mamy;
coś nam użyczył z łaski swej,
niech to będzie w opiece twej,
jenż z Ojcem i z Duchem Świętym
jesteś Królem wiekuistym.



CRITICAL NOTES

(P_{WM}), (K) and (M) transpose up a minor third, halve the values, bar in 4/4 and use a signature of three flats. Their readings are given here at the pitch and in the values of this edition. Bar numbers agree in all four.

BAR	VOICE	NOTE
1–2	A	(P _{WM}) splits the dotted minim f' so that 'się' has a note of its own. (A) has one dotted minim; 'się' falls on the following e'.
4	C	(P _{WM}) raises the semiminim g' as well as the cadential minim. Only the minim is raised here, as in (K) and (M).
8–10	A, T	(M) exchanges the two parts, 'for tessitura'. (A) has the semiminims c' b a g and the descent f e d in the Altus.
8–9	A	(P _{WM}), (K): 'ga' on the semiminim c', 'o' on f. Here 'ga' on f and 'o' on e, so that 'pomoc' falls with the Cantus and Tenor.
12–13	C, B	Parallel fifths d'–g' over g–c. They stand in (A).
15–17	C	(P _{WM}), (K), (M): 'złych' on the semiminim g', bar 17. Here on c'', bar 16, the semiminim straight after the dotted minim of 'od'. 'Czar-' takes the leap c'–c'' and the run down from it, and 'tów' the dotted minim e' and the semiminim after it, so that 'nas o-bro-' falls on g' a' g# as 'chy-tro-' does at the final cadence. In stanza 2 'wicz-' takes c', 'ny' the run, and 'spra-' the semibreve a'.
23	A	(K), (M): 'cej' on the second semiminim a. Here on b, straight after the dotted minim.
27–29	C	(P _{WM}), (K), (M) put 'ja' on the e' of bar 27. Here 'ja' c' and 'swej' d', bar 28, each with the minim after it; 'chy-' the semibreve d' and 'tro-' c#, a minim after the other voices. (A) leaves a gap after 'Vżywá', which keeps the e' of bar 27 within the melisma. Stanza 2: 'na-' c', 'sze' d', 'wo-' e' and the semibreve d', 'ła-' c#.
28	A	(M): 'ja' on the second semiminim c'. Here on d', straight after the dotted minim.
29	A	(P _{WM}), (K) and (M) flatten b (<i>una nota super la</i>). Left as in (A): bb would sound a tritone against e' in the Cantus, and b is the sixth degree of the D mode. The flat is printed in brackets as an option. A KEPT.
30	B	(A) has a maxima, given as a longa to match the other voices.
text		(P _{WM}): 'zmierzcha', 'naszym stróżem'. (K), (M): 'naszym strażem'; (M) 'zmierzcha'. All three print 'On' with a capital. (A): 'zmyerzka', 'nássem strážem', 'nawyęcęcy', 'on'.

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